that ‘all the individual Tata Companies’ are nothing but ‘branches of the same tree with a common trunk and common roots. … So let us make a sincere effort to keep the roots strengthened and the tree alive. On my part I assure you that I am willing to make any sacrifice, even at personal cost, should the need arise.’

On Ratan’s appointment, Kerkar congratulated him and termed it ‘not only an appropriate choice’ but also the ‘beginning of an even more exciting chapter in the Group’s history’. The letter expressed hope that he and the new chairman would work closely for the implementation of shared goals of both the company and the group. However, Kerkar was habituated to working independently. He was largely unused to securing approvals from the holding company or even sharing details of his plans. Ratan had encountered this side of his many years before becoming chairman.

In 1986, the Prime Minister’s Office (PMO) requested from Ratan a note on how the Tata companies would increase foreign exchange earnings. Ratan, in turn, asked all the companies to share their plans with him. The information from Indian Hotels Company Limited (IHCL) was, however, not forthcoming. After nearly four months of making the request and ‘several reminders’ and personal telephone calls from Ratan, the response was still a stony silence. Ratan had to finally explain to the PMO that the group’s presentation was delayed because the plan was not forthcoming from IHCL.

After becoming chairman, when Ratan again asked for details of IHCL’s working, Kerkar recoiled. He found little reason to share the information, particularly because he felt that the group had extended IHCL virtually no financial support for its projects.

The first signs of the emerging difference in perception between Kerkar and Ratan became apparent during the company’s board meeting on 16 June 1994, when the IHCL warrants issue came up for discussion. The proposal was for Tata companies and associate companies of the Taj Group to subscribe to its warrants. Ratan was ‘not in favour of associate companies of the Taj Group taking up the warrants by themselves as this would further dilute the direct holdings of Tata Sons and the Tata Trusts’. Kerkar thought otherwise and found little reason for Tata Sons to interfere in the working of the hotel company.

Kerkar wanted to keep IHCL as almost an independent company, without any strong bond with Tata Sons. Consequently, he was also not supportive